Employee Handbook & HR Policy

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Owner: Human Resources Department, Northwind Dynamics Ltd.

1. Purpose and Scope

This handbook sets out the employment policies of Northwind Dynamics Ltd. (a fictional company created for training purposes). It applies to all full-time and part-time employees, including those in probation. Contractors and interns are covered only where stated.

1.1 Employment Categories

Category	Definition
Full-time	40 hours per week. Eligible for all benefits in this handbook.
Part-time	Fewer than 30 hours per week. Leave is pro-rated by hours worked.
Probationary	First 90 days of employment. Benefits apply except where noted.

Questions about interpretation should be sent to hr-help@northwind.example. Where this handbook conflicts with local law, local law prevails.

2. Leave Entitlements

2.1 Annual Leave

Full-time employees receive 20 days of paid annual leave per calendar year. Leave accrues at 1.67 days per month of service. Part-time employees accrue leave pro-rated to their contracted hours. Leave must be requested at least 5 business days in advance and approved by the line manager.

2.2 Carry-Over

A maximum of 5 unused annual leave days may be carried into the next calendar year. Carried-over days expire on 31 March. Unused leave above the cap is forfeited and is not paid out, except on termination (see Section 5).

2.3 Sick Leave

Employees receive 10 paid sick days per calendar year. A medical certificate is required for absences of more than 2 consecutive days. Employees must notify their manager before 09:30 on the first day of absence.

2.4 Parental Leave

Type	Entitlement
Maternity leave	12 weeks fully paid
Paternity leave	2 weeks fully paid, to be taken within 6 months of the birth
Adoption leave	Same as maternity leave for the primary caregiver

Leave during probation: employees in probation accrue annual leave but may only take up to 5 days before completing probation.

3. Working Hours and Remote Work

3.1 Standard Hours and Core Hours

Standard working hours are 40 hours per week. Core hours are 10:00 to 15:00, Monday to Friday, during which employees are expected to be available. Start and finish times outside core hours are flexible with manager agreement.

3.2 Hybrid and Remote Work

Employees may work remotely up to 3 days per week under the hybrid model. Fully remote arrangements require written approval from both the line manager and the HR Director. Remote employees must use the company VPN when accessing internal systems (technical requirements are set out in the IT Support Policy, IT-POL-2026).

3.3 Home Office Support

Approved hybrid and remote employees are eligible for a one-time home office stipend. The amount and the claim process are administered by Finance and are described in the Finance Policy (FIN-POL-2026). HR confirms eligibility only.

3.4 Overtime

Non-exempt employees are paid 1.5 times their hourly rate for approved overtime beyond 40 hours per week and 2 times the hourly rate for work on public holidays. Overtime must be pre-approved by the line manager. Exempt (salaried management) roles are not eligible for overtime pay.

4. Probation, Performance and Notice

4.1 Probation

All new employees serve a 90-day probation period. A probation review takes place at day 75. Probation may be extended once by up to 30 days with written notice.

4.2 Performance Reviews

Performance is reviewed twice a year, in June and December. Ratings use a five-point scale. Salary adjustments are considered only after the December review and take effect on 1 February.

4.3 Notice Periods

Situation	Notice required
Resignation during probation	7 days
Resignation after probation	30 days
Termination by company after probation	30 days (or pay in lieu)

4.4 Training Budget

Each employee may request internal training. Details of external course funding are not covered in this handbook; employees should consult their department head.

5. Conduct, Onboarding and Offboarding

5.1 Code of Conduct

Employees are expected to act with integrity, respect colleagues, protect confidential information and avoid conflicts of interest. Harassment and discrimination are prohibited. Concerns may be raised confidentially with HR or through the ethics hotline.

5.2 Onboarding

On the first day HR issues the employment pack and requests IT to prepare accounts and equipment. New starters complete mandatory compliance training within 14 days.

5.3 Offboarding

On resignation or termination, HR notifies IT and Finance. Company equipment must be returned within 5 business days of the last working day. Final pay is processed in the next payroll cycle. Unused annual leave is paid out on termination at the daily rate (annual salary divided by 260).

5.4 Equipment Return

Unreturned equipment may be deducted from final pay in line with local law. The technical process for wiping and re-issuing devices is owned by IT.

6. Contacts and Revision History

Topic	Contact
Leave and payroll queries	hr-help@northwind.example (ext. 2001)
Recruitment and onboarding	talent@northwind.example (ext. 2005)
Ethics hotline	ethics@northwind.example (ext. 2999)

Revision History

Version	Date	Change
3.0	1 Jan 2025	Carry-over cap reduced from 10 to 5 days
3.1	1 Jan 2026	Hybrid model extended to 3 days; sick leave raised from 8 to 10 days

This document is fictional and was created for a RAG training assignment.